

Apple Beats Powerbeats Fit

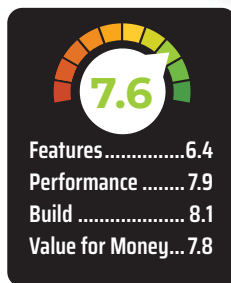
Secure workout earbuds that work on the daily

When you think of Beats, bass and lifestyle are probably what come to your mind. But the Powerbeats Fit, which follow the Beats Fit Pro, are positioned very differently. Beats is pitching these as performance-first earbuds for people who move. Their sound is meant to keep your pace up in gyms and treadmills primarily. So, when the Beats earbuds landed on my desk, I was interested in seeing how they sounded and also how they lived up to the name. I also had the Sony LinkBuds Fit with me, which I've compared to the Powerbeats Fit in the past. And while I have used them both during working out at home, commuting to work and back, and for everyday calls and music, here the focus stays on the Powerbeats buds. Here's how they actually felt while using.

A SECURE FIT

The Powerbeats Fit are an evolution of the old Beats Fit Pro, but wrapped in the 'Powerbeats' branding. That itself says a lot. This is the same family as Powerbeats Pro, just without the ear-hooks. Instead, it has the wingtip, which is said to be around 20% more flexible than before. In use, the Powerbeats' wingtips are long and can be easily tucked in.

While worn, they offer a good seal and stability. I never felt they would fall out. At times, however, that secure seal was causing a slight sensation of pain. At 5.78 grams each, it is a tad heavier than the LinkBuds Fit (4.9 grams). This isn't to say they are heavy, but I could definitely feel their presence.



Looks-wise, though, the Gravel Grey colour of our review unit was swish. You can pick it in three more colours, viz., black, orange, and pink. The case shares the colours and is rounded and easy to pocket.

The colours aside, the Beats 'b' logo on the earbuds and the case can be a fashion statement. The 'b' on the right bud is a multifunctional button. A physical button allows easy and precise control of the earbuds' various functions like calls, music and switching between ANC and Transparency mode. I like this, especially since a sweaty or moist finger doesn't necessarily work well with the touch controls.

By the way, both buds and case are IPX4 rated. Sweat and rain are fine, but dust resistance and submersion ratings would have been more welcome for runners hitting trails.

ANDROIDS AND IPHONES

On iPhone, this is plug and play. Flip open the lid, the pop-up appears, pair once, and you are done. To initiate manual pairing, put the buds back in the case and press the circular button for 5 seconds. Automatic switching between iPhone, iPad, and Mac works as expected. 'Hey Siri' is available hands-free. You also get Find My support, though not precision finding like newer AirPods cases.

The Powerbeats Fit still use the H1 chip, though, not the newer H2 found in AirPods Pro 2 and later. So, you are missing the H2 features like 2x better active noise cancellation (ANC), a newer adaptive transparency mode, and a longer runtime than the H1.

ANC, transparency mode, and Spatial Audio with head tracking are there.

And compared to the Sony LinkBuds Fit, you get fewer customisation options and features in the Beats app. Powerbeats Fit keep things simple with settings like Automatic Ear Detection, in-ear fit test, button controls, etc.

While connected to an Android, it is still a better option than the AirPods. You get the Beats app, which gives pairing help, firmware updates, battery info, ear tip fit test, and basic controls. Sure, you do lose some Apple magic like Personalised Spatial Audio, Find My and seamless connectivity, but the core experience holds together.

CALLS AND CONNECTIVITY

The connection itself is stable. No dropouts in metro, walking between rooms in my house, etc. There is no true multipoint across different ecosystems, which Sony offers. But like we said, within Apple's world, auto-switching fills most of that gap.

Latency while watching YouTube and Netflix, and playing games, was fine.

Call quality is fine. Indoors, voices sounded clean and natural. Outdoors, some of the traffic and crowd noises were seeping in, more than on AirPods Pro 3 (with H2 chip).